

NO ROLLS-ROYCE, PLEASE

Mr. Allan is extremely perceptive in his understanding of under accumulators of wealth. In essence, he feels that products change people. If you acquire one status product, you will likely have to purchase others to fill up the socially conspicuous puzzle. Before long, your entire lifestyle will have changed. Mr. Allan clearly understands the complementary nature of status products and a high-consumption lifestyle. He will have none of these artifacts. They are a threat, as he sees it, to his rather simple yet highly efficient lifestyle:

Building wealth is not something that will change your lifestyle. Even at this stage of life, I don't want to change the way I live.

Mr. Allan's values and priorities were recently tested. Several of those people whom Mr. Allan helped stay in business decided to purchase a special birthday gift for him. What a nice gesture, they thought. But status gifts, whether from friends or rich parents, are not always congruent with the recipient's values and lifestyle. And often such gifts place tremendous pressure on the recipients to spend more and more of their income to "fill in the picture."

Some wealthy parents buy their adult children homes in affluent neighborhoods. Great idea? Perhaps they should realize that "affluent neighborhoods" are high-consumption neighborhoods. From property taxes to the pressure to decorate, from the perceived need to send their children to expensive private schools to the \$40,000 four-wheel-drive luxury Suburban, the children are now on the earn-to-spend treadmill. Thanks, Mom and Dad!

As Mr. Allan, the super-PAW, told us:

Something interesting recently happened. I discovered I was to be given a surprise present [from several close business associates]. A Rolls-Royce for a present! It was ordered for me